Casting Rules

Volume 02 — locked in on top of Volume 01. These rules apply to every chapter from April 28, 2006 onward.

Rule 1 — Real Actors Keep Their Roles

Every MCU character keeps the real-life actor who played them, **except for the twelve roles listed in Rule 2**. They are cast in the story through realistic Hollywood channels: auditions, agents, screen tests, negotiations and press leaks.

Rule 2 — The Twelve Roles for Fictional Actors

#	Role	Character (comic-accurate)	Fictional actor (locked)
1	Iron Man	Tony Stark	Marc-Anthony Bullock
2	Hulk	Bruce Banner / Hulk	Amond Baker
3	Captain America	Steve Rogers	Tyrese Avery
4	Ant-Man	Hank Pym *(founding Avenger)*	David Tipton
5	Wasp	Janet van Dyne *(founding Avenger)*	Elxa Bullock
6	Black Widow	Natasha Romanoff	Harmony Divine
7	Thor	**Thor, daughter of Odin — always female**	Esther Smilley
8	Hawkeye	**Claire Barton — always female**	Arianna Cummings
9	Scarlet Witch	Wanda Maximoff	Grace Bullock
10	Pepper Potts	Virginia "Pepper" Potts	Tayia Boyd
11	Bucky Barnes	James Buchanan "Bucky" Barnes / Winter Soldier	Tyler Chapman
12	Quicksilver	Pietro Maximoff	Elijah Blackman

Rule 3 — Thor and Hawkeye Have Always Been Women

- **No legacy and no passing the torch.** Thor has always been Odin's daughter, and Hawkeye has always been Claire Barton. There was never a male version.
- **Everything else stays comic-accurate.** Thor is the God of Thunder, Loki is her adopted brother, she is worthy of Mjolnir, and she has full godly power with no nerfs. Claire Barton's history follows Clint's from the comics: the carnival, Trick Shot and the Swordsman, her start as a reformed criminal, and joining the Avengers in *Avengers* #16 (1965).
- **In the real-world story,** this is a creative decision Marvel Studios makes. Trade press, fans and message boards react to it the way they really would have in 2006 and 2007.

Rule 4 — Ages and Availability of Real Actors

Real actors are cast at a believable moment in their real careers, with their real ages. Ages on April 28, 2006:

Actor	MCU role	Born	Age (4/28/06)
Samuel L. Jackson	Nick Fury	Dec 21, 1948	57
Anthony Hopkins	Odin	Dec 31, 1937	68
Jeff Bridges	Obadiah Stane	Dec 4, 1949	56
Hugo Weaving	Red Skull	Apr 4, 1960	46

Actor	MCU role	Born	Age (4/28/06)
Clark Gregg	Phil Coulson	Apr 2, 1962	44
Josh Brolin	Thanos	Feb 12, 1968	38
Paul Bettany	Vision	May 27, 1971	34
Chadwick Boseman	Black Panther	Nov 29, 1976	29
Benedict Cumberbatch	Doctor Strange	July 19, 1976	29
Anthony Mackie	Falcon	Sept 23, 1978	27
Chris Pratt	Star-Lord	June 21, 1979	26
Tom Hiddleston	Loki	Feb 9, 1981	25
Hayley Atwell	Peggy Carter	Apr 5, 1982	24
Tom Holland	Spider-Man	June 1, 1996	9

A sample, not the full list. Every real actor gets added to the age register the first time they appear.

Confirmed Decisions

You answered these on Volume 02's open questions. They are now locked canon.

#	Topic	Locked decision
1	Thor's name	**Thor**, daughter of Odin and Frigga. Her formal Asgardian name is "Thor Odinsdottir."
2	Ant-Man and Wasp	**Hank Pym and Janet van Dyne**, founding Avengers from *Avengers* #1 (1963), both played by fictional actors. Scott Lang comes later as the second Ant-Man, played by his real actor, Paul Rudd.
3	Roles with more than one real actor	The actor most identified with the role: **Josh Brolin** as Thanos and **William Hurt** as Thunderbolt Ross. Howard Stark is recast; see row 8.
3a	**Exception: Rhodey**	Rhodey keeps his **real casting history**. **Terrence Howard** (born March 11, 1969; 37 today) plays him in *Iron Man*. **Don Cheadle** (born November 29, 1964; 41 today) replaces him from *Iron Man 2* on. The recast plays out in the real-world story as it did in real life: contract talks, trade headlines and fan reaction.
4	Characters never played in the MCU	Keep the actor most identified with the role, for example **Hugh Jackman** as Wolverine.
5	Real-life tragedies	Real history stays the same. Events like Chadwick Boseman's death in August 2020 will happen, and I'll handle them respectfully, the way real life did.
6	Claire Barton's love life	**Locked: Claire has Clint Barton's comic love life.** Her partners are the same: an early romance with **Natasha Romanoff** (Harmony Divine), marriage to **Bobbi Morse / Mockingbird**, played by Adrianne Palicki as in *Agents of S.H.I.E.L.D.*, now canon, and later **Jessica Drew / Spider-Woman**.
7	Hope van Dyne vs. Nadia van Dyne	**Locked: no Hope van Dyne. Nadia van Dyne (the Unstoppable Wasp), Hank Pym's daughter, is played by real-life actress Yara Shahidi** (born February 10, 2000; age 6 today). She is cast through normal Hollywood channels, and she is not a fictional-actor role. Her biracial heritage echoes Nadia's mixed heritage in the comics. Evangeline Lilly is not cast.

#	Topic	Locked decision
8	Tony Stark's parents (recast with real Black actors to match Marc-Anthony)	**Locked. Young Howard Stark: Michael Ealy** (born Aug 3, 1973), in *Captain America: The First Avenger* and *Agent Carter*, replacing Dominic Cooper. **Older Howard Stark: Andre Braugher** (born July 1, 1962), in every appearance through *Avengers: Endgame* (2019), replacing John Slattery. After Braugher's real death on December 11, 2023, which happens in our story too, **any later appearance by the older Howard is played by Courtney B. Vance** (born Mar 12, 1960). **Maria Stark: Vanessa Williams** (born Mar 18, 1963), replacing Hope Davis.
9	*Ant-Man* (2009) supporting cast	**Locked. Paul Giamatti** (born June 6, 1967) as Egghead (Elihas Starr), Hank Pym's archenemy. **Delroy Lindo** (born Nov 18, 1952) as Dr. Vernon van Dyne, Janet's father, killed by the Kosmosian alien as in *Tales to Astonish* #44. Both are real actors with no other MCU role.